cottoned on to what was happening and froze the accounts, Rs 12 crore had already been withdrawn. Both Sukash and Leena were arrested, though no charges could be brought against her eventually because no evidence was found to indicate her involvement except that she may have posed as Sukash/ Jayakumar's secretary over the phone.

Around the same time as he was masterminding this con, Sukash ran a parallel fraud in 2013. A stray advertisement in the daily newspaper by a textile firm called Skylark had caught his attention. "We tailor large quantities of clothes under bulk orders," the ad read. Posing again as Karnataka IAS officer Jayakumar, he contacted the company over the phone, and told them he could get them a contract for school uniforms worth Rs 400 crore in return for a commission. Of course, the firm was left poorer by Rs 84 lakh by the time they discovered they had been scammed; Sukash himself had long vanished.

After securing bail in the bank fraud case, the couple moved to Mumbai and got married in 2015. In Maximum City, the duo ran a ponzi scheme through an unregistered firm called Lion Oak India, promising people high returns. All the investments, ranging from Rs 5,000 to Rs 5 lakh, were accepted only in cash and never deposited in any bank. Sukash would roam around with four bodyguards and a dummy pistol. The walls of his office in Goregaon had fake M.F. Husain paintings. A sword displayed prominently was passed off as once having belonged to Alexander the Great, which, he told potential investors, he had bought at an auction. Unfortunately for him, this run came to an end after the Mumbai Police arrested him in 2015 on an unknown tip-off that he was running an unregistered investment scheme and defrauding investors.

THE PRIVILEGED PRISONER

Sukash allegedly paid more than Rs 12 crore to jail officials for five-star facilities, which included an exclusive barrack, a car inside the prison to ferry guests and access to mobile phones and internet



GETTY IMAGES

Inside Delhi's Rohini jail complex, Sukash was allotted an entire barrack (No. 204), usually shared by 15–20 inmates. He enjoyed several luxuries, including his own BMW car inside the prison to ferry the occasional guests. The car reportedly had a sticker of the Tihar Jail. He had amenities such as air-conditioning, smartphones and television while other inmates washed his clothes and utensils. CCTV cameras in his barrack were blocked using curtains and mineral water bottle boxes. When he was out on interim bail in November 2020 to perform his father's last rites, he allegedly stayed out of jail for six months "under mysterious circumstances".

These privileges came for a price. According to the Delhi Police chargesheet, deputy jail superintendent D.S. Meena used to collect Rs 60–75 lakh every fortnight from Sukash's aides Deepak Ramnani and Pradeep Ramdanee. Of that money, around Rs 50 lakh was given to officers above the rank of assistant superintendent and Rs 10 lakh to those below that rank, the chargesheet states, quoting Meena's confessional statement to the police. Meena allegedly collected kickbacks 35 times.

Following Sukash's arrest in August 2021 in the Aditi Singh extortion case (wherein he conned her of over Rs 200 crore), and the subsequent ED probe, he was sent to Tihar jail. In February 2022, he was back in the news with fresh charges of bribing three officials in Tihar's Jail No. 4. He was then shifted to Jail No. 1. Later, he and his wife Leena moved the Supreme Court, seeking transfer out of Tihar Jail, claiming a threat to their lives there. The apex court ordered transfer to Mandoli Jail, an extension of Tihar Jail only. Sukash is now moving court seeking transfer to a jail not under the Tihar administration.

Meanwhile, the Economic Offences Wing of the Delhi Police has booked 81 staffers of the Rohini jail on corruption charges. Eight jail officials, including Meena, were arrested for allegedly helping Sukash con Aditi Singh. ■